High Political Wind in Bengal

- On March 10, West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee announced candidates for all 42 Lok Sabha seats
- It has ended hopes for a seat sharing arrangement between Congress and TMC, both members of the I.N.D.I.A. bloc
- With the TMC now taking on the BJP alone, they are fighting to woo the state's 37 million women voters, 50 per cent of whom voted TMC in the 2021 assembly polls
- The BJP has been trying to create a narrative of worsening conditions for women under TMC rule
- To do this, they are citing the alleged abuse of women by TMC leaders in Sandeshkhali
- To counter the BJP, the TMC has highlighted the state's various welfare schemes targeting women
- In February, salaries were hiked for both ASHA workers and integrated child development service (Anganwadi) providers
- For the Lakshmir Bhandar payouts for women, amounts have been increased both for women in the general category and the reserved category

and-effect colour to it. However, while the TMC has decided to take on the BJP alone on its own turf, a tug of war has now broken out between the archrivals over the women voters of Bengal, with the BJP making desperate attempts to deplete Mamata's support base in the wake of the Sandeshkhali incident.

Apart from the minorities, the women of Bengal have traditionally been the staunchest supporters of the TMC. While 47 per cent of Bengal's women voted for Mamata in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, 50 per cent of them did so in the 2021 assembly polls. Mamata has always played the women's card wisely. Be it reserving 50 per cent of seats for them in the three-tier panchayat system in the state, or announcing women-centric schemes such as the direct benefit transfer programme Lakshmir Bhandar, women have been a priority for the chief minister. However, in February, when hundreds of women in the Sandeshkhali area in North 24 Parganas district openly protested alleged sexual crimes and land-grabbing by local TMC henchmen, the saffron party lunged at the opportunity to establish a narrative that the state failed to ensure safety for women.

APART FROM THE MINORITIES, WOMEN VOTERS IN BENGAL HAVE ALWAYS BEEN AMONG THE TMC'S STAUNCHEST SUPPORTERS

Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself attacked the TMC multiple times over the Sandeshkhali issue between March 2 and 6, during which he addressed three political rallies in Bengal. "The women of Bengal and the entire country are angry with what happened to the mothers and sisters of Sandeshkhali," Modi said in Barasat on March 6. The PM also met and spoke to five women who were allegedly victims of the atrocities.

Faced with this potent attack, the TMC decided damage control action. On March 6 itself, the state government announced a hike in the salary of Accredited Social Health Activist (ASHA) workers and Integrated Child Development Service (ICDS) providers. In February, state finance minister Chandrima Bhattacharya announced that the honorarium under Lakshmir Bhandar for the general category women of general category will be doubled to Rs 1,000 and that for reserved category hiked to Rs 1,200 from Rs 1,000.

"For the PM, women are just voters. But Didi has worked for the inclusive development and empowerment of the women," said Shashi Panja, minister for industries and department of women and child development in Bengal. "There are countless initiatives that Didi's government has taken. What has the Centre done? Has the PM visited the oppressed women of Manipur even once?" Panja asked.

In its poll campaign, the BJP plans to highlight the steps the Centre has taken to improve women's lives, especially passing the women's reservation bill, which reserves 33 per cent seats for women in the Lok Sabha and the state assemblies.

The TMC claims that it has pioneered the cause of women's reservation. It cites the nomination of 17 women amongst the 42 Lok Sabha candidates in 2019. In the 2021 assembly polls, 50 per cent of 294 TMC candidates were women. The number has dropped in 2024, though. The list of nominees announced by the TMC on February 10 includes only 12 women.

BJP MLA Agnimitra Paul dismisses the TMC's "tall claims". "The chief minister thinks she can pay doles to women and buy their dignity. She is mistaken. The women of our state are realising her hypocrisy and retaliating," Paul said. Bengal's electorate has over 37 million women voters. For both the TMC and the BJP, there is a lot riding over securing their votes. ■